

Daan van der Weijden

PhD Candidate, Dynamic and Distributed Information Systems (DDIS)

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Artificial intelligence and its impact on democracy: conversational agents and voting advice applications, adaptive political surveys, online deliberation at scale, and the accessibility of complex political and legal information. Computational social science and human-centred machine learning, applied to societal problems in an interdisciplinary setting.

EDUCATION

Sep 2023 – present	PhD in Computer Science University of Zurich, Switzerland — DDIS, Department of Informatics Advisor: Prof. Dr. Abraham Bernstein. Part of the interdisciplinary Digital Deliberative Democracy (D3) project.
Sep 2021 – Aug 2023	MSc in Artificial Intelligence Utrecht University, the Netherlands Thesis: <i>Dutch Data Augmentation for Low-Resource Tasks</i> , carried out at TNO, The Hague. Supervisors: Prof. Dong Nguyen (Utrecht University) and Dr. Saskia Lensink (TNO). GPA 3.7/4.0. Graduate Honours of Interdisciplinary Seminars.
Sep 2019 – Aug 2021	BSc in Artificial Intelligence (<i>cum laude</i>) Utrecht University, the Netherlands Thesis: <i>Transitiviteit van Inferentie in Nederlandse Machine Learning NLI modellen</i> . Supervisor: Dr. Gijs Wijnholds. GPA 4.0/4.0.
Sep 2017 – Aug 2021	BA in Linguistics Utrecht University, the Netherlands Thesis: <i>Finding the Best Approach for Reasoning about Monotonicity</i> . Supervisor: Dr. Gijs Wijnholds. GPA 3.8/4.0.

PUBLICATIONS

My name is shown in bold. Listed newest first within each category.

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

- [J1] Bachmann, F., **D. J. van der Weijden**, Sarasua, C., & Bernstein, A. (2026). Estimating the recommendation certainty in candidate-based voting advice applications. *Politics and Governance*, 14. doi:10.17645/pag.11256
- [J2] Bachmann, F., **D. J. van der Weijden**, Heitz, L., Sarasua, C., & Bernstein, A. (2025). Adaptive political surveys and GPT-4: Tackling the cold start problem with simulated user interactions. *PLoS ONE*, 20(5), e0322690. doi:10.1371/journal.pone.0322690
- [J3] van Es, K., **D. J. van der Weijden**, & Bakker, J. (2023). The multifaceted and situated data center imaginary of Dutch Twitter. *Big Data & Society*, 10(1). doi:10.1177/20539517231155064

Peer-Reviewed Conference Papers

- [C1] **D. J. van der Weijden**, Brack, N., & Báez Santamaría, S. (2026). Reproducing and evaluating the generalizability of subliminal learning in open-weight models. In *Proceedings of the Ninth Workshop on Analyzing and Interpreting Neural Networks for NLP (BlackboxNLP '26)*, co-located

with EMNLP 2026, Budapest, Hungary. Reproducibility Challenge track.

Accepted; to appear.

[C2] **D. J. van der Weijden**, Dieing, T. I., & Bachmann, F. (2026). Towards a typology of user engagement in conversational agent voting advice applications. In *Proceedings of the ACM Conference on Conversational User Interfaces (CUI '26)*, Bremen, Germany. doi:10.1145/3816046.3816272
Best Poster Honorable Mention. Equal author contribution.

[C3] Rossetto, L., Sarasua, C., Inel, O., Bermeo, J. D., Bolaños, P. S., Devimeux, H., Duan, H., Hany, R., Kyriakou, A., Ramasamy, D., Ravikumar, V. G., Timoleon, K., Vasu, R., Wang, R., **D. J. van der Weijden**, Willi, J., & Bernstein, A. (2025). Alan's Speakeasy — An ecosystem for the evaluation of conversational agents. In *Companion Proceedings of the ACM Web Conference 2025 (WWW '25)*, pp. 2895–2898. doi:10.1145/3701716.3715165
Demo Paper Third Place Award.

[C4] van Rosmalen, Y., van der Steen, F., Jans, S., & **D. J. van der Weijden** (2022). Bursting the burden bubble? An assessment of Sharma et al.'s counterfactual-based fairness metric. *Benelux Conference on Artificial Intelligence (BNAIC/BeNeLearn '22)*, Mechelen, Belgium. arXiv:2211.11512

Research Reports

[R1] Bakker, J., de Graaf, B. A., Prins, S., Schaefer, M., & **D. J. van der Weijden** (2024). *Playing with fire: How the interplay between the Dutch House of Representatives and social media fuels rage*. Utrecht University / Utrecht Data School. dataschool.nl

AWARDS, GRANTS & HONOURS

Jul 2026	Best Poster Honorable Mention ACM Conference on Conversational User Interfaces (CUI '26), Bremen
Jun 2026	Engagement Award for Special Commitment (<i>nominee</i>) Faculty of Business, Economics and Informatics, University of Zurich For work as PhD representative and member of hiring committees at the Department of Informatics.
Apr 2025	CIRES Travel Grant Funding a research visit to the University of Queensland, Brisbane
Apr 2025	Demo Paper Third Place Award The Web Conference 2025 (WWW '25), demo track
Sep 2024	DSI PhD Excellence Program & Personal Grant Digital Society Initiative, University of Zurich Competitive interdisciplinary programme; personal research grant of CHF 5,000.

CONFERENCE & WORKSHOP PRESENTATIONS

Oct 2026 (<i>upcoming</i>)	Reproducing and Evaluating the Generalizability of Subliminal Learning in Open-Weight Models BlackboxNLP '26 at EMNLP 2026, Budapest
Jul 2026	Towards a Typology of User Engagement in CAVAAs ACM Conference on Conversational User Interfaces (CUI '26), Bremen — poster
Nov 2025	Personalised Summarisation for Swiss Leaflets Digital Democracy Workshop, Digital Society Initiative, University of Zurich With Cristina Sarasua and Abraham Bernstein.
Jun 2025	AutoDQI: An Automated Measurement of Deliberation Quality EDDY 2025, Centre d'Économie de la Sorbonne, Paris

Apr 2024	Partisan Bots or Neutral Models? Politically Aligning Large Language Models EDDY 2024 — Digital Democracy: Bridging Theory and Practice, Erasmus University Rotterdam — poster With Fynn Bachmann, Cristina Sarasua and Abraham Bernstein.
Nov 2022	Bursting the Burden Bubble? BNAIC/BeNeLearn 2022, Mechelen
Jun 2022	Infrastructures of Data Power: Revisiting the Twitter Debate on Data Centers in the Netherlands Dialogues in Data Power, ZeMKI, University of Bremen With Karin van Es and Jeroen Bakker.
Jun 2022	Interviewing an Algorithm: Developing a Research Method for Critical Inquiry into Algorithmic Systems from a Socio-Cultural Perspective Dialogues in Data Power, ZeMKI, University of Bremen With Iris Muis, Mirko Tobias Schäfer, and Arthur Vankan.

STUDENT SUPERVISION

Sep 2025 – Sep 2026	Marlon Gelpke & Kim Hyeongseok — <i>Debate Bots: A Multi-Agent Interactive Environment for Swiss Political Debates</i> MSc research project, University of Zurich Co-supervised with Selene Báez Santamaría.
Sep 2025 – Mar 2026	Jana Joy Muheim — <i>Designing Debate Bots Interface</i> BSc thesis, University of Zurich
Jul 2025 – Jan 2026	Wesley Muri — <i>Clustering Swiss Politics</i> MSc thesis, University of Zurich
Oct 2024 – Oct 2025	Zihan Liu & Zehao Zhang — <i>Front-End Enhancement of the Online Discussion Platform CitizenOS</i> MSc research project, University of Zurich
May 2024 – Nov 2024	Hasan Atak — <i>Automated Drafting of Swiss Popular Initiatives Through Large Language Models</i> MSc thesis, University of Zurich
Feb 2024 – Aug 2024	Julian Novoa Martin — <i>Improving the Automatic Measure of Discourse Quality</i> MSc thesis, University of Zurich
Aug 2023 – Jul 2024	Wesley Muri & Yuru Jin — <i>Practical Applications of Large-Language Models for Legal Use Cases</i> MSc research project, University of Zurich Co-supervised with Fynn Bachmann.

TEACHING

Fall 2024, Fall 2025	Advanced Topics in Artificial Intelligence Teaching assistant, MSc course, University of Zurich
Fall 2022	Machine Learning Teaching assistant, Utrecht University
Spring 2021	Natural and Formal Languages Teaching assistant, Utrecht University
Fall 2020	Introduction to Logic Teaching assistant, Utrecht University

RESEARCH & PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Dec 2022 – Aug 2023	Research Intern TNO, The Hague Researched textual data augmentation methods; developed augmentation techniques for Dutch using locally hosted large language models.
Jan 2022 – Aug 2023	Research Assistant Utrecht Data School, Utrecht Analysed Twitter discourse on Dutch data centers (published in <i>Big Data & Society</i>); developed an algorithmic oversight framework for public authorities; conducted research on political influence on social media.

RESEARCH VISITS

2025	Visiting Researcher University of Queensland, Brisbane, Australia Funded by a CIRES Travel Grant.
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ACADEMIC SERVICE & ENGAGEMENT

Current	PhD Representative Department of Informatics (IfI), University of Zurich Represents the doctoral community; member of hiring committees.
2024 – 2026	Member of the Faculty Assembly Faculty of Business, Economics and Informatics (OEC), University of Zurich
2024	Reviewer AAAI/ACM Conference on AI, Ethics, and Society (AIES '24); Extended Semantic Web Conference (ESWC 2024); Digital Democracy Workshop 2024
2024	Organising Committee, Digital Democracy Workshop 2024 Digital Society Initiative & Digital Democracy Lab, University of Zurich
2021 – 2023	Faculty Council Member Faculty of Science, Utrecht University
2020 – 2021	Chair, student political party VUUR Utrecht University
2018 – 2019	Chair, Linguistics study association Utrecht University

LANGUAGES

Dutch (native), English (fluent), German (working knowledge)